

In the AI Era, Is Your Brand Part of the Answer?

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Just three and a half years after ChatGPT's arrival, the pace of change has been so rapid that it feels like we've entered a different era. I worked as a merchandiser when Fashionplus launched in 2000. Back then, online shopping meant slowly browsing products by clicking through menus one level at a time. Even seemingly minor questions—such as whether a two-level navigation structure (“Brand > Jackets”) was more user-friendly than a three-level hierarchy (“Brand > Apparel > Jackets”)—were the subject of serious consulting discussions.

As the internet evolved through the era of webzines and online communities, brands built trust through content and user experience. Then came the search era, when consumers stopped navigating menus and began typing keywords into search bars instead. In response, brands focused on Search Engine Optimization (SEO) to improve their visibility in search results.

Today, with the rise of generative AI, the consumer journey is undergoing yet another transformation. Nowhere is this shift more evident than in the fashion industry. Consumers ask highly specific, contextual questions such as, “Can you recommend running shoes for this season?” “Which brands are known for gorpcore?” “What clothes should I pack for a trip to Vietnam?” or “Can you recommend blouses that flatter the midsection?”

In this new environment, the brands recommended by AI increasingly influence purchasing decisions. Competitive advantage no longer depends solely on whether consumers can find your brand—it depends on whether your brand appears in AI-generated answers. The priority is no longer just Search Engine Optimization (SEO), but ensuring that generative AI understands your brand. This is the foundation of **Generative Engine Optimization (GEO)**.

So where should fashion e-commerce platforms begin if they want to become AI-ready websites?

The first step is allowing AI crawlers to access the site through the `robots.txt` file and providing the data they need to interpret the brand. An `llm.txt` file should contain information such as the brand's identity, URLs for new product releases, FAQs, and sizing information. Product information should also be structured using the Schema.org standard.

Rather than limiting metadata to SKUs and prices, brands should organize information in a format AI can easily interpret, including style looks, TPO (Time, Place, Occasion), body-type recommendations, style preferences, seasonal suitability, and fabric functionality. For standardized product attributes, brands can reference Google Merchant Center specifications, incorporate them into their databases, and embed them within HTML. Ultimately, the key is data architecture.

Much of this process can be automated using generative AI infrastructure. By building on a foundation model (general-purpose large language model) and training it with a company's proprietary unstructured data, businesses can create customized AI models tailored to their brands.

A Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) agent can then retrieve relevant information from the database to generate brand-specific product pages, while simultaneously converting the content into structured data that AI crawlers can immediately parse and understand.

Consider a customer searching for “a flowy resort dress with a feminine silhouette.” A RAG agent could automatically retrieve product attributes from the database—such as **Material: Linen**, **TPO: Travel Wear**, **Silhouette: H-Line**, and **Fit: Loose Fit**—populate the corresponding Schema.org fields, and generate customer-facing product descriptions at the same time.

With a well-designed database and a customized AI model, brands can simultaneously automate website content creation and build AI-friendly product information. As these models learn from hundreds of thousands of product records, they can automatically generate product detail pages tailored to a brand’s identity while optimizing descriptions so that key product attributes naturally surface in AI-generated recommendations.

The online store of the future will no longer be merely an e-commerce website. It must become an AI-friendly platform that AI systems can read, understand, and recommend before consumers ever visit it.

In the AI era, branding can no longer rely solely on compelling imagery or emotionally resonant copywriting. Competitive advantage will increasingly depend on the quality and structure of the data that AI can understand. Brands must translate their identity into structured data and standardized attributes, then present that information in formats optimized for AI consumption.

The future is one in which AI understands and recommends brands before customers discover them. To ensure your brand becomes part of AI-generated answers, now is the time to evaluate your data. Well-prepared data will be the foundation of brand competitiveness in the age of AI.